The Prescott Girls - Study Guide

Needlework and Girls’ Education in Early America

During the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, girls’ education often included learning needlework. Embroidery, sewing, and sampler making were considered essential skills, not only for practical household use but also for developing patience, discipline, and literacy.

The samplers stitched by the Prescott and Canby families in the early 1800s are examples of this tradition. These carefully embroidered pieces show how young girls learned reading, writing, and moral instruction alongside practical skills.

What Is a Sampler?

A **sampler** is a piece of embroidery used to practice stitches and record patterns.

The word comes from the Latin word **exemplar**, meaning a model or example. Early samplers served as reference pieces where needleworkers recorded stitches they could later use in clothing or household textiles.

By the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries in America, samplers had become a regular part of girls' schooling.

Most school samplers included:

- rows of alphabets
- numbers
- decorative borders
- moral or religious verses
- the maker's name and age

These elements demonstrated that a girl had learned both needlework and basic literacy.

Why Did Girls Stitch Samplers?

Sampler making served several purposes in early American education.

Learning Practical Skills

Needlework was an important household skill. Girls were expected to sew clothing, repair garments, and mark linens with family initials.

Samplers allowed students to practice stitches such as:

- cross stitch
- eyelet stitch
- satin stitch
- stem stitch

These stitches would later be used for clothing and household textiles.

Practicing Literacy

Many samplers included full alphabets and numbers. Stitching letters helped reinforce reading and writing skills.

Because many families marked household linens with embroidered initials, girls needed to learn how to stitch letters clearly and consistently.

The alphabets on samplers served both a decorative and practical purpose.

Teaching Moral Lessons

Samplers often included short verses about virtue, patience, and kindness.

These verses reflected the moral instruction that children were expected to learn. Families believed that education should shape both the mind and character.

One common example found on samplers is the **Golden Rule**:

“Do unto others as you would have them do unto you.”

These sayings reminded students of the values their families and communities believed were important.

Samplers as Personal Records

Many samplers also served as personal records of the girl who made them.

Most included inscriptions such as:

- the maker’s name
- her age
- the year the sampler was completed
- sometimes the town where it was stitched

Because of this information, samplers often provide historians with valuable clues about families and communities.

For example, Beckie Prescott’s sampler reads:

“Rebecca G. J. Prescott aged eight years — Dresden Maine 1835.”

This simple inscription tells historians who made the sampler, where she lived, and how old she was at the time.

Schools and Needlework

In many towns, girls learned needlework at home, in small local schools, or in academies.

Some schools became well known for their distinctive sampler styles. Quaker schools such as **Westtown School near Philadelphia** were especially known for geometric designs and balanced compositions.

Even when girls did not attend large schools, teachers often followed similar patterns of instruction.

The Prescott family samplers show the influence of these broader traditions while also reflecting local teaching styles.

What Samplers Teach Us Today

Samplers are more than decorative works of embroidery. They are historical documents that reveal:

- how girls were educated
- what skills families valued
- how literacy and needlework were connected
- how young people expressed identity and learning

Because many samplers include names and dates, they also help historians trace family histories and understand everyday life in early America.

Questions for Discussion

1. Why do you think needlework was considered an important skill for girls in the 1800s?

2. How did sampler making combine practical skills with education?

3. Why might families want girls to include moral verses on their samplers?

4. What can historians learn from objects made by children?

5. What skills do students today learn that might leave records for future historians?

Activity

Look closely at a historical sampler or an image of one.

Try to identify:

- alphabets
- numbers
- decorative borders
- a verse or saying
- the maker’s name and age

Imagine you were creating your own sampler today. What words or designs would you include to represent your life and values?